GRØD, for the Product Practice · October 2026

Your notes are your notes.

A few things I learned whilst building a memory for my meetings.

Alex Holley



“

I don’t believe you should pay someone a monthly fee to get to your own notes.

Me, before the first commit

So I built one for myself.

There was no market gap or competitor teardown behind it. I take a lot of calls, and I wanted the notes without them living in someone else's service.

First commit: 15 July 2026, with eighty-two more that day.

GROD-PRD.md — Draft for build

Owner	Product Design
Audience	Claude Code / engineering
Platform	macOS only, Apple silicon
Target OS	macOS 14 Sonoma+ (open)
Date	14 July 2026

The spec from the day before the first commit had twelve sections and twelve decisions. Look at who it was for.

The shape of it

Ninety-eight days, five acts.

I
The itch
15 July

A plan that lasted a day.

II
The climb
15 to 24 July

Always one level up.

III
The reckoning
18 to 23 July

A promise I broke.

IV
The turn
From 25 July

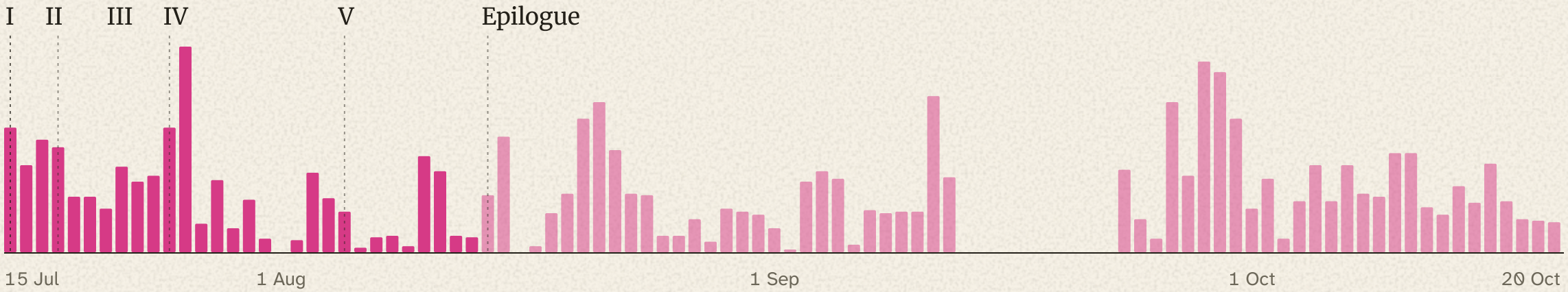
Stop adding.

V
The subtraction
5 to 13 August

Delete something.

Ø
Epilogue
To today

A stranger can install it.



Act I · 15 July

The itch.

A spec with twelve decisions, written the day before. Its plan lasted about a day.



Act I

The spec was wrong in a day but still did its job.

	The spec said	What shipped	When
Speech to text	~~whisper.cpp with CoreML~~	*Apple's SpeechAnalyzer*	Day one
Summaries	~~Llama 3.2 3B via MLX~~	*Apple's Foundation Models*	Day one
Minimum macOS	~~14, Sonoma~~	*26, Apple silicon only*	Day one
Calendar	~~Not in version 1~~	*An up-next card, auto-record*	Cycle 14
Network	~~Off, permanently~~	*On, for model downloads only*	Day four

What survived, untouched

- Local by construction.
- Calm, not surveillance.
- Your notes stay yours.
- Markdown as the common language.
- Degrade gracefully.

What I learned

Hold principles tightly and technology loosely. The technology will change first.

Receipt GROD-PRD.md, 14 July

Act I · decided on day one

The best decision was a constraint.

I chose
macOS 26 and Apple silicon only

→ So
macOS brings the speech and language models

→ So
Nothing to download when you install

→ So
No server to run

→ So
No subscription to justify

What it cost

Fewer people can run it. I chose that on day one and wrote it down.

What it bought

A privacy claim you can check, and no monthly fee.

What I learned

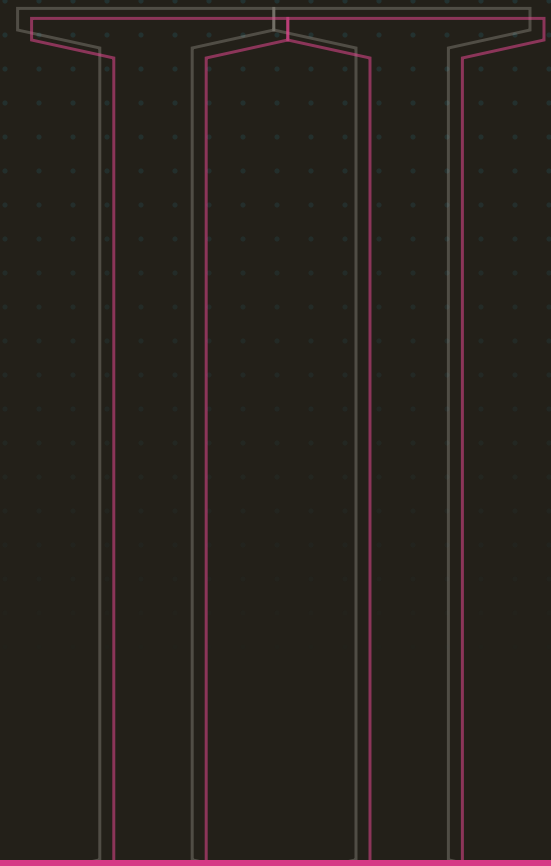
Look for a constraint that removes work. Mine removed the server, the downloads and the subscription.

Receipt Decision O2, 15 July

Act II · 15 to 24 July

The climb.

Ten days, about a cycle a day. Each one found what mattered a level above where it was looking.



What mattered was always one level up.

What I learned

If something works but doesn't land, look one level up. That's usually where the value is.

Receipt decisions.md, cycles 1 to 14

Cycle 1

Capture

Both sides, on this Mac.

Cycle 1

Notes

Nobody re-reads an hour of talk.

Cycle 2

Search

An archive only helps if you can search it.

Cycle 4

People

Name a voice once, and every meeting knows it.

Cycle 14

Calendar

Knowing what the meeting was, not only that it happened.

August

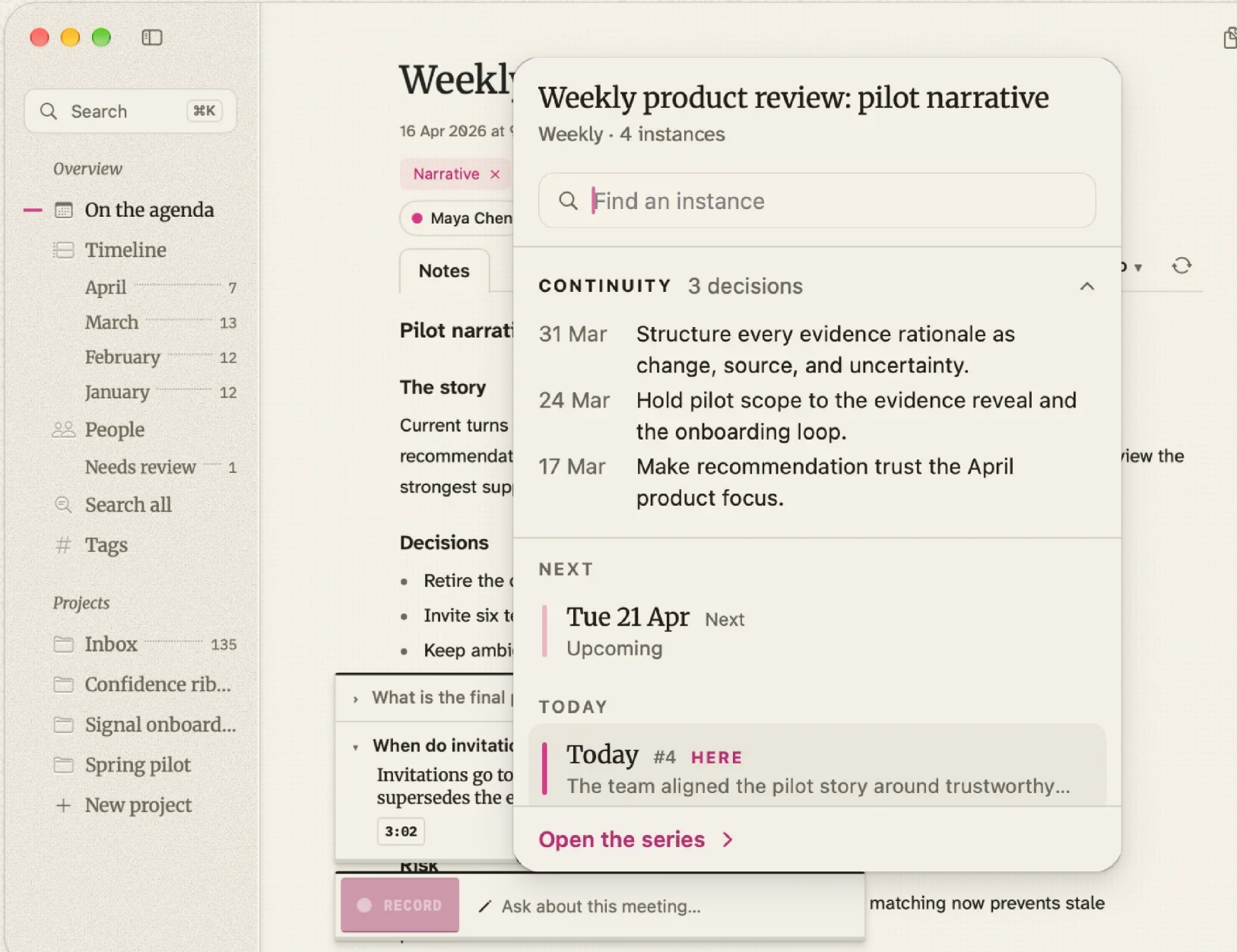
Series

The weekly review as one thing across time.

One more level up, in August

The weekly standup became one object.

Forty unrelated rows became one series with continuity and cadence. It was the project's largest design cycle.



Meanwhile

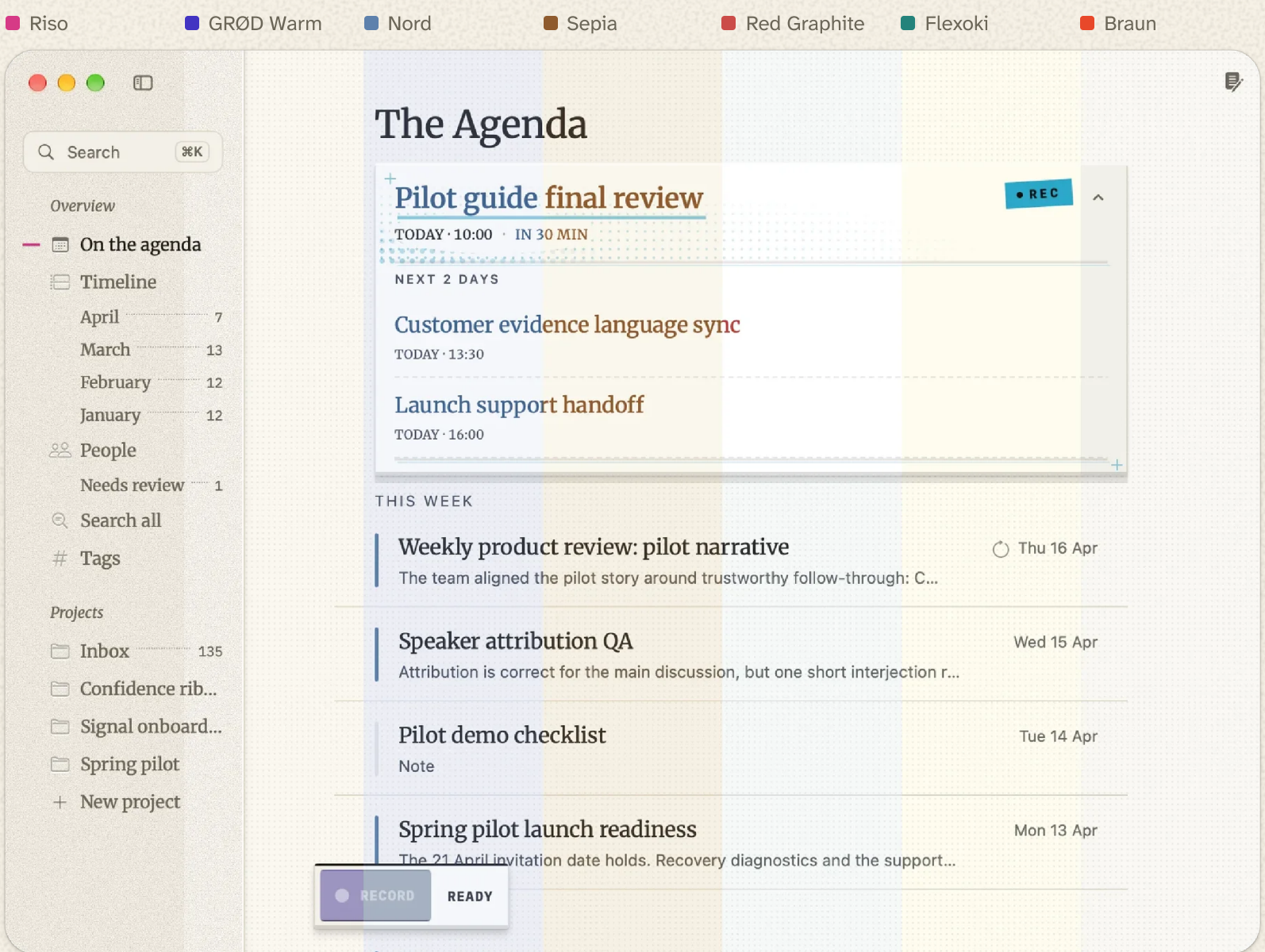
It got a personality.

Themes printed like inks, a reading font, dock styles named for Fukasawa and Castiglioni, and oats in the overscroll.

What I learned

The agents could build anything but couldn't tell when it was shouting, so taste stayed mine.

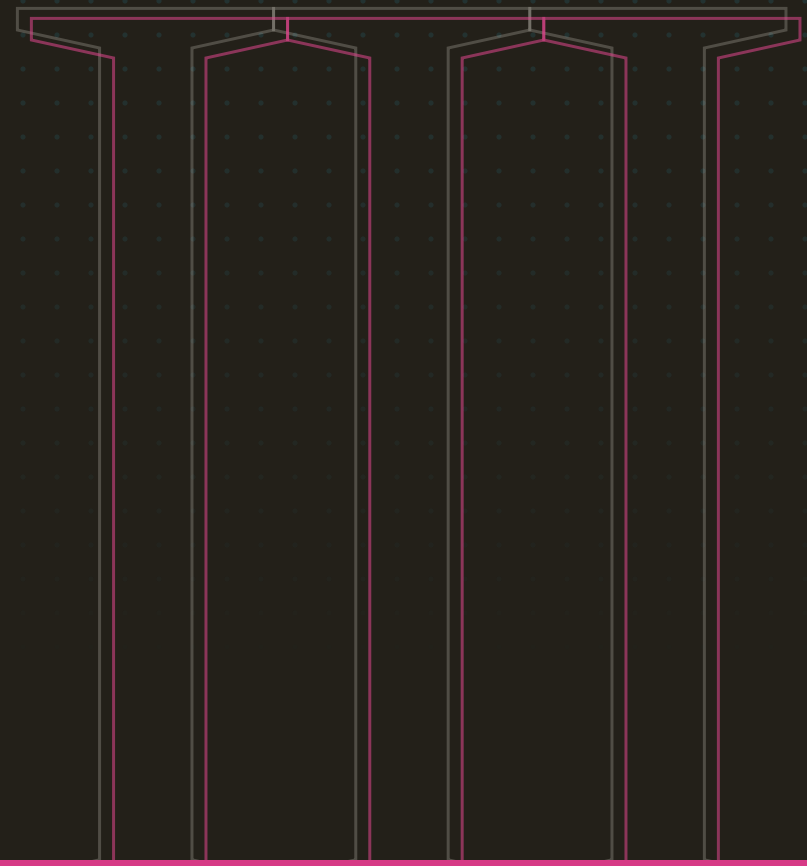
Receipt HOL-115 keeps em dashes out of anything a user reads



Act III · 18 to 23 July

The reckoning.

The best line in the pitch stopped being true, and nobody had noticed.



Act III

Then I broke my own promise.

decisions.md D8

No outbound network entitlement. The privacy promise is structurally impossible to break.

No longer true
18 July

Optional transcription models had to be downloaded, so the network entitlement went on and the best line in the pitch became false.

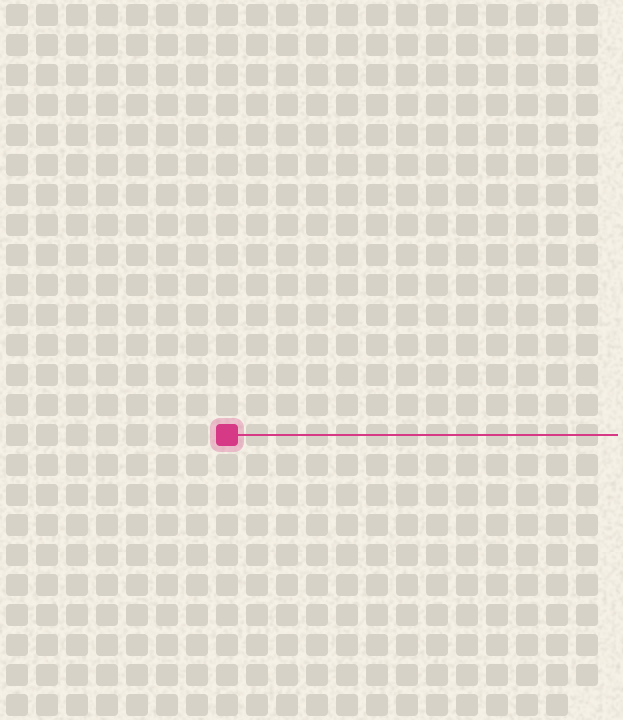
Nobody had noticed, and the cheap fix was to soften the wording and move on.

Act III · five days later

So I made it narrower, and harder to break.

Your meeting content never leaves this Mac.

I rewrote every sentence to name its actor (GRØD, macOS or another app) and banned the old sentence by name.



Every square is a file in GRØD's source.

One door

Of 479 source files, one may open the network. A test reads the source and fails the build if a second one tries.

What I learned

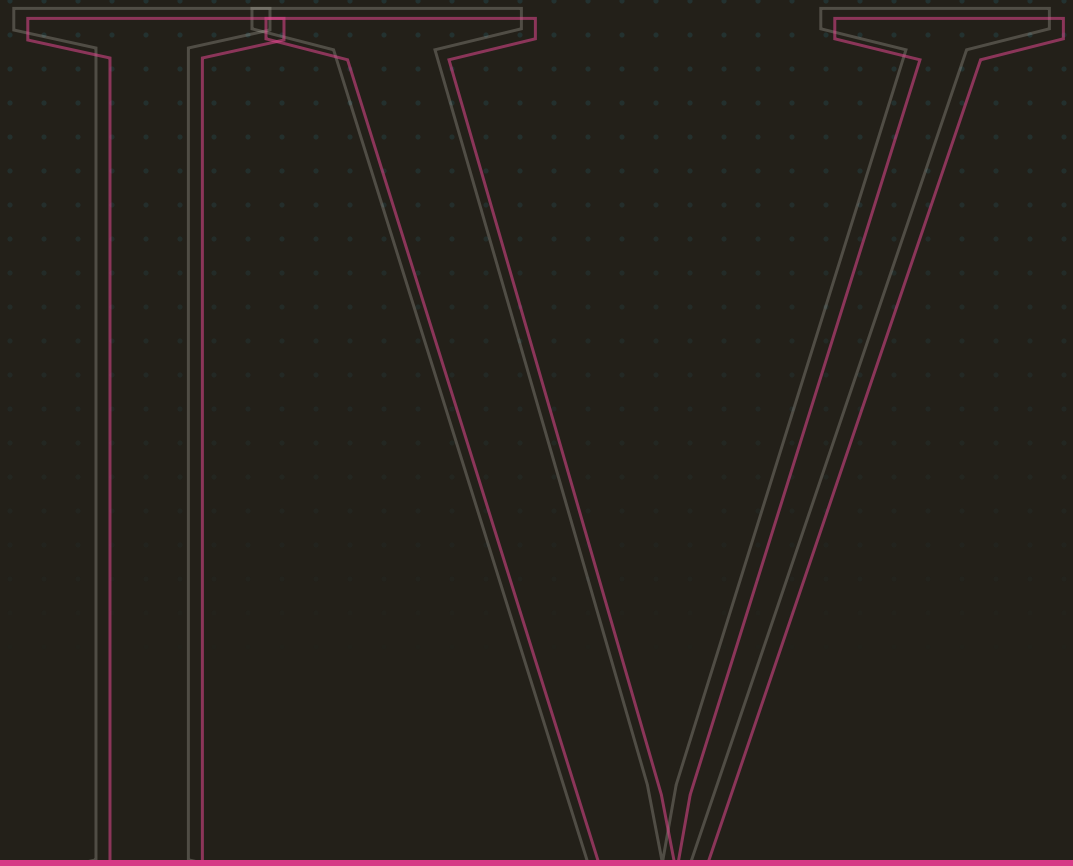
Don't leave what matters to memory. A page waits to be read. A check in the process finds the next person for you.

Receipt NetworkChokePointTests

Act IV · 25 July

The turn.

Ten days in, I had a beautiful app that only worked on one machine, so I stopped adding things.



The 1.0 bar, written 25 July and unchanged since.

Never loses a meeting, and a stranger can install it.

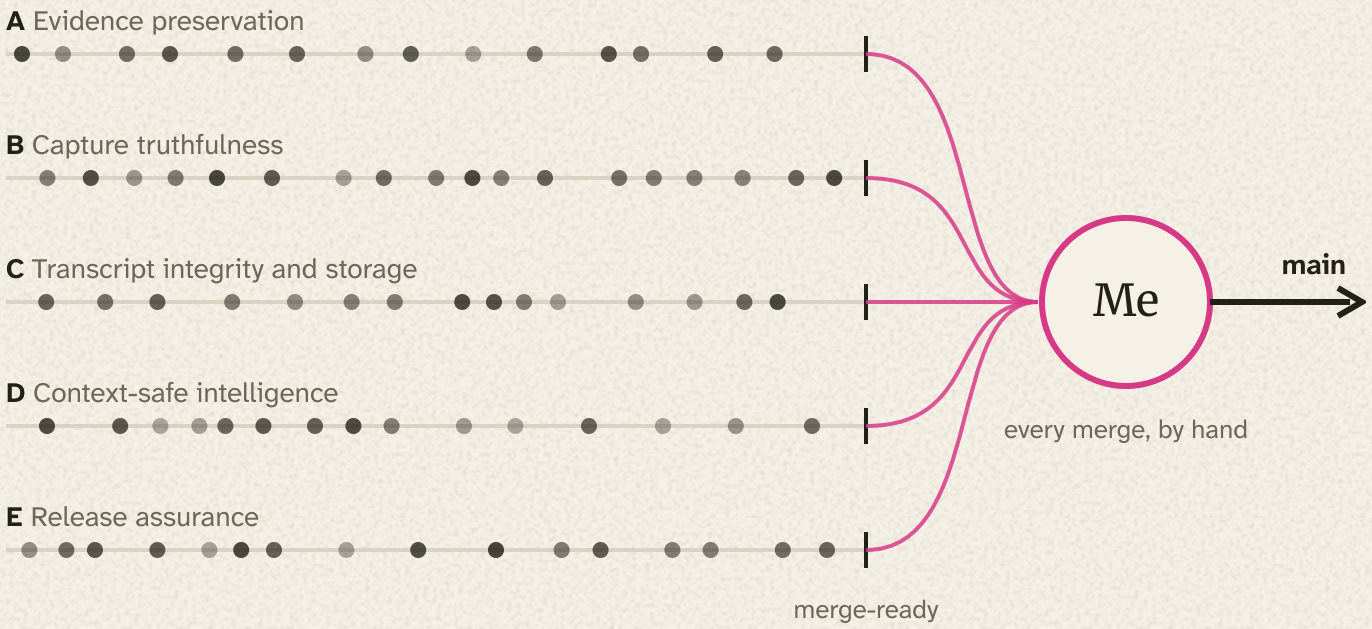
Both clauses can be tested in the field, and neither can be gamed. It stopped the delight work and put everything into hardening.

What I learned

“95% capture success” starts a negotiation. A sentence tells you what to do on a Tuesday.

Receipt It is why onboarding blocks the release.

Five lanes, one gate. The gate was me.



What I learned

Once building got cheap, my job became deciding what has to happen first and where the boundaries sit.

Receipt The lane landing entries, decisions.md

Each lane ran on its own to merge-ready. Plausible work can merge cleanly and still be wrong in combination, and that is what the gate caught.

Act IV · the division that settled

Who owned what.

Me	The agents
What the product is	What the code is
Whether a decision is right	Whether it is consistent
Every merge	Every branch, up to merge-ready
Taste, and when something is shouting	Coverage, and the long tail
Knowing when to stop	Not knowing when to stop

What the agents got wrong, in their own words

- Read a tool that reported nothing as proof that nothing happened.
- Fixed the same race four times before looking for the family.
- Called work verified when a command had only exited zero.

What I learned

I couldn’t review 106,000 lines of Swift. I could review what 153,000 lines of tests promised.

Receipt The agent’s own write-up, 08-how-we-worked.md

Act IV · the stack

On the Mac, all the way down.

macOS supplies

SpeechAnalyzer · Foundation Models · EventKit · Core Audio taps · NaturalLanguage embeddings

GRØD's services, with no UI inside them

Capture → Transcription → Intelligence → Storage

Search: by the words used and by what was meant, fused into one list

What you touch

The SwiftUI app · Markdown export · An MCP server, read-only, off by default

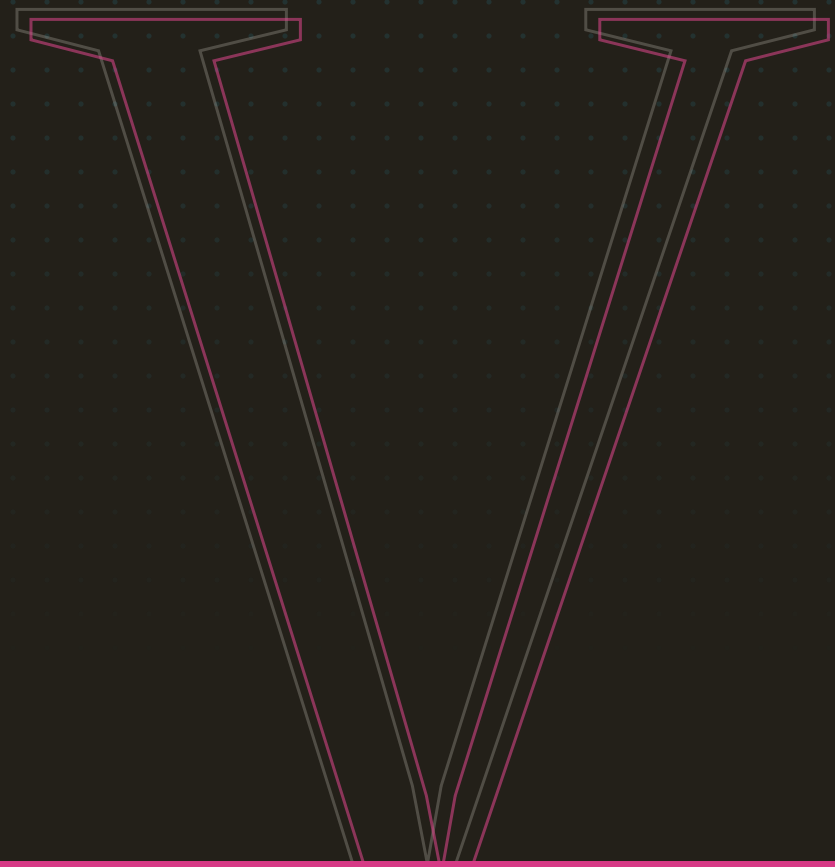
How it was made

- Claude Code and Codex, in parallel lanes
- Linear for tickets, GitHub for 305 pull requests
- FluidAudio for telling voices apart
- The website: Astro on Cloudflare

Act V · 5 to 13 August

The subtraction.

I deleted one feature on purpose and kept putting off one piece of work.



Act V · deleted 5 August

~~Quick Peek~~

“A regression nobody notices is a feature nobody uses.”

It was named in the spec, shipped in cycle five and liked. Then opening a meeting became free, and the preview saved one gesture while showing less.

What I learned

Before you can delete a feature, you need a record of why it exists and some sign that it’s dead.

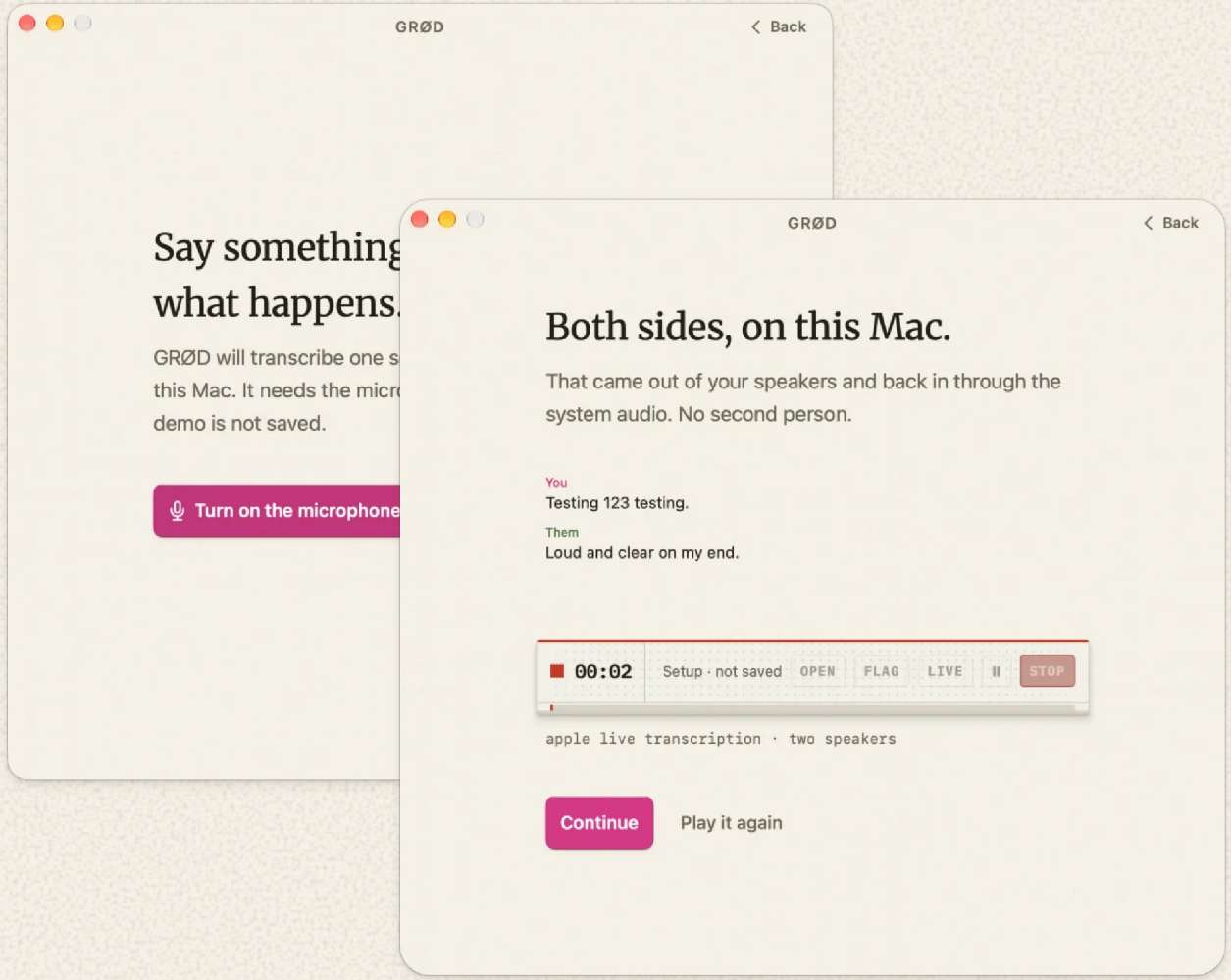
Receipt decisions.md, 5 August

Act V

What I'd do differently.

Onboarding lost every prioritisation contest for weeks, because I'd been a user for months and the stranger never had.

So it went first and blocked the release. Now the first run asks you to say something, and shows you.



What I learned

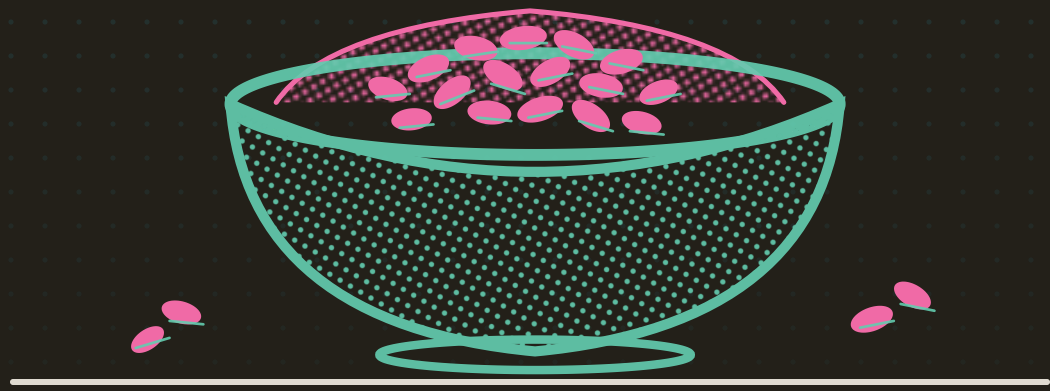
The first five minutes lose every contest they enter, so schedule them first or let them block the release.

Receipt Lesson 10, in my own write-up

Epilogue · 14 August to today

Breakfast.

Onboarding, a beta, a website, a privacy policy, and a company to ship it under.



Epilogue

Then I owned the rest of it.

24 Sep	The first run's words, locked
25 Sep	Version 0.6 goes to TestFlight
1 Oct	gaspery.com/grod goes live
2 Oct	A privacy policy of its own
9 Oct	New captures, a new film
Today	A public TestFlight link

What I learned

With one client (me), the whole outcome was mine, from the app to the paperwork.



gaspery.com/grod: the home page, Features, Craft, Privacy and an FAQ, shipped under Gaspery Limited.

15 July to 20 October

Ninety-eight days, in numbers.

3,606
commits

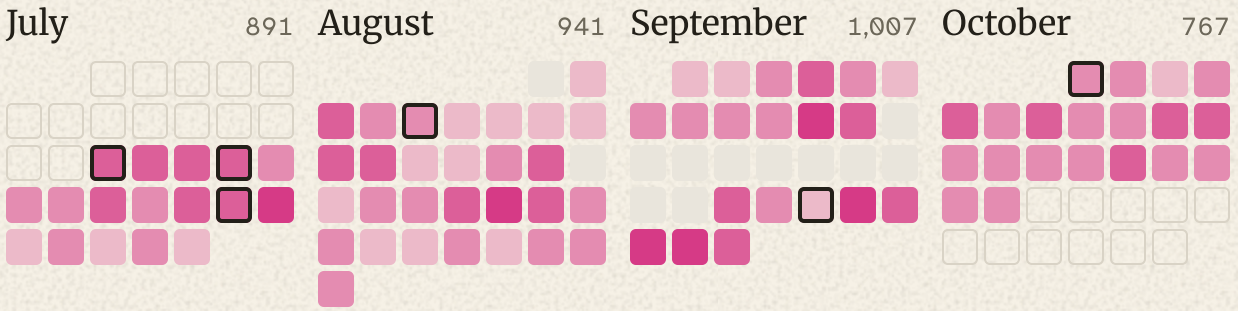
305
pull requests, merged by hand

6,000+
tests

427
decisions written down, with why

1
feature deleted on purpose

0
servers



Fewer more commits a day a moment in the story

15 Jul First commit
18 Jul The promise breaks
25 Jul The 1.0 bar
5 Aug Quick Peek deleted
25 Sep 0.6 on TestFlight
1 Oct The site goes live

Generosity

What I’m bringing back to the practice.

The cycle	Brainstorm, spec, plan, build, then write down why. A way to run agent-built work that someone else can audit.
Lanes and a gate	Agents in parallel without the mess: each lane stops at merge-ready, and a person merges.
Checks, not pages	Building what a client must never lose into how the team works, so nobody has to remember it.
Lessons with receipts	Ten of mine, and the agents’ own account of what went wrong.

Ask me for any of them.

In August the story ended “breakfast is nearly ready”.

Breakfast is ready.

A stranger can install it now. If you have a Mac with Apple silicon and macOS 26, so can you.

Join the TestFlight beta

testflight.apple.com/join/pufKwmNU

Scan to join the beta



GRØD